MODULE 38 · DOMAIN 3 - BUSINESS ENVIRONMENT

Continuous improvement and OPAs

Improvement at team, project and organisation level: retrospectives that change things, Lean waste, value stream mapping, and updating process assets.

DOMAIN III - Business Environment EXAM WEIGHT 26% MODULE 38 of 49

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Improvement that is not built into **how work is done** does not last.

Improvement at three levels

LEVEL	HOW IMPROVEMENT HAPPENS	WHERE IT IS KEPT
Team	Retrospectives; small experiments each iteration	Working agreements, definition of done
Project	Lessons applied during the project, not saved for the end	Plans, checklists, the lessons register
Organisation	Lessons turned into standard practice across projects	Process assets: templates, methods, benchmarks

ON THE EXAM

The outline's third enabler reaches the organisation level: update organisational process assets.

Retrospectives that change things

- Choose **one or two** improvements, not ten.
- Give each an **owner**, and put it in the backlog or plan so it gets done.
- Start the next retrospective by **checking** whether last time's actions worked.
- Vary the format so people keep thinking, rather than repeating the same answers.
- The same complaints at every retrospective mean the actions are not being done.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> A retrospective is judged by what changes afterwards, not by the quality of the discussion.

Retrospective formats

FORMAT	PROMPTS
Start, stop, continue	What should we start, stop, and keep doing?
Liked, learned, lacked, longed for	Four angles on the last iteration
Sailboat	Wind that pushed us, anchors that held us back, rocks ahead
Timeline	Map events and feelings across the period, then look for patterns
Five whys on one problem	Go deep on a single recurring issue

ON THE EXAM

The format matters less than the follow-through. Pick one that fits the team's mood and the period.

Kaizen and plan, do, check, act

- **Kaizen**: continuous, small improvements, by everyone, every day.
- Each change is an experiment: **plan** it, **do** it small, **check** the result, **act** to keep or drop it.
- Measure before and after, so you know the change helped.
- Once a change works, **standardise** it. Then improve from the new standard.

> ON THE EXAM
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> Small, measured, repeated. Improve, standardise, improve again.

Lean: eight kinds of waste

WASTE	IN PROJECT WORK
Defects	Rework, bugs, errors found late
Overproduction	Features nobody uses; reports nobody reads
Waiting	Queues for approvals, environments, answers
Unused talent	People's skills and ideas ignored
Transport and handoffs	Work passed between many people or teams
Inventory	Half-finished work: too much in progress
Motion	Task switching; hunting for information
Extra processing	Steps, signatures or documents that add no value

ON THE EXAM

In knowledge work, waiting is usually the biggest waste. Look for it first.

Value stream mapping

- Map every step from **request** to **value delivered**, with the time each takes.
- Separate **work time** from **waiting time**.
- A change request takes 30 days end to end. The actual work is 4 days. The rest is waiting for approvals.
- Improve the waits first: they are usually where most of the time goes.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> When something takes too long, map the flow before speeding up the work. The delay is usually in the waiting.

Using lessons learned

- The outline's first enabler: **utilise lessons learned**, not just record them.
- At the start: search the repository and plan with what it says (module 16).
- During the project: apply this project's own lessons to the next phase or iteration.
- A lesson written down but not acted on is only a lesson **identified**. It is learned when behaviour changes.

> ON THE EXAM
>
> Lessons identified become lessons learned only when the next piece of work is done differently.

Updating process assets

LESSON FOUND	PROCESS ASSET UPDATED
Estimates for integration always run 40% low	Estimating benchmarks and templates
Go-lives kept missing a training step	The go-live checklist
The same supplier risk recurs on every project	The organisation's risk checklist
A new review step caught many defects	The standard quality procedure
Contracts lacked a data-return clause	The standard contract template

ON THE EXAM

The outline asks you to update organisational process assets. That is how one project's lesson helps every project.

Project Lantern: improving as it went

- After the pilot clinic, a retrospective produced two actions; both were in the next clinic's plan.
- A value stream map showed kiosk orders waiting eight days for sign-off; approval was delegated, cutting it to one.
- The go-live checklist was updated after each clinic, then adopted by Northgate's PMO for all projects.
- By clinic six, go-live issues had fallen from fourteen to two.

ON THE EXAM

Small actions, owned and followed up; waiting found and removed; a project checklist became an organisational asset.

Scenario signals and the move

THE SCENARIO SAYS	THE MOVE
Same problems at every retrospective	Fewer actions, with owners, checked next time
A lesson recorded but a new phase is starting	Apply it to the plan now
An organisational template is proven wrong	Update the process asset with the PMO
Work takes weeks but effort is days	Map the value stream; remove the waiting

ON THE EXAM

Use lessons, build them into the process, and make them part of the organisation's assets.

> At every retrospective for the last four sprints, the team has raised the same two problems and agreed eight or more actions. Few of the actions have been completed.
>
> Team members say retrospectives feel pointless.

What should the project leader do?

A. Help the team choose one or two actions, each with an owner, add them to the backlog, and review them at the next retrospective.

B. Make retrospectives longer, so more actions can be discussed.

C. Stop holding retrospectives until the team has more time.

D. Decide the improvement actions personally, to save the team's time.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project leader do?

A Fewer actions, owned, in the backlog, reviewed.
Makes improvement actually happen, and restores the retrospective's value.

B Longer retrospectives.
More talk, more actions, the same lack of follow-through.

C Stop retrospectives.
Removes the team's main improvement mechanism.

D The leader decides.
Takes improvement away from the team that must own it.

THE SIGNAL

Repeated problems and unfinished actions: fewer, owned, visible actions, checked next time.

> The lessons learned register from phase one of a programme records that clashing bookings for the test environment caused two weeks of delay.
>
> Phase two, which needs the same environment, starts next week.

What should the project manager do?

A Add another note about test environment clashes to the register.

B Apply the lesson now: put a booking process for the test environment into the phase two plan.

C Wait to see whether clashes happen again in phase two.

D Email the lesson to the phase two team for awareness.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Note it again.
Records the lesson a second time without acting on it.

B Apply it: booking process in the plan.
Turns a lesson identified into a lesson learned, before it recurs.

C Wait and see.
Invites the same two-week delay.

D Email it.
Awareness alone rarely changes behaviour.

THE SIGNAL

A known lesson and the same situation coming: change the plan before it starts.

> A project manager has found that the PMO's standard estimating template underestimates data integration work by about forty percent. Three recent projects confirm the pattern.
>
> Other project managers across the organisation use the same template.

What should the project manager do?

A. Share the evidence with the PMO and work with them to update the template and benchmarks.

B. Adjust this project's own estimates, and leave the template as it is.

C. Email other project managers to warn them informally.

D. Keep using the template, since it is the organisation's standard.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager do?

A Update the template with the PMO.
Updates an organisational process asset, so every project benefits.

B Fix only this project.
Helps one project; every other one keeps underestimating.

C Informal warning emails.
Unreliable, and the template stays wrong for new users.

D Keep using it.
Knowingly uses a flawed standard.

THE SIGNAL

A proven flaw in a shared template: fix the process asset itself, with its owner.

> A team's minor changes take about thirty days from request to release. A value stream map shows about four days of actual work, and twenty-six days waiting for three separate approvals.
>
> The sponsor asks how to speed up delivery.

What should the project manager recommend?

A. Add more developers to the team.

B. Work with the approvers to reduce the waiting, for example by delegating approval of minor changes.

C. Ask the developers to code faster.

D. Add a fourth approval to improve quality.

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the project manager recommend?

A More developers.

Speeds up the four days of work, not the twenty-six of waiting.

B Reduce the approval waiting.

Targets the biggest waste the value stream map revealed.

C Code faster.

Same problem as A, with added pressure.

D Another approval.

Adds more of the waste that is causing the delay.

THE SIGNAL

The map shows where the time goes. Here, 26 of 30 days are waiting. Fix the waiting.

Use the lesson. Build it into the process.
Update the asset.

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